

FREEDOM FINDS A NEW MEANING IN DHARAVI

The Dharavi Redevelopment Project is laying the foundation for people-first townships where dignity, livelihoods, opportunity and environment grow together

By Dr Mahendra Kalyankar, CEO and Officer on Special Duty, DRP/SRA

Few public infrastructure projects in independent India match the scale and complexity of the Dharavi Redevelopment Project. Designed to improve the lives of more than 10 lakh people, it is as much a social transformation programme as it is an urban redevelopment initiative. While the scale of construction is unprecedented, the true measure of the project will be the lives it changes.

That is why redevelopment in Dharavi has always been about much more than new buildings. It is equally about livelihoods, education, health, public spaces and creating opportunities for future generations.

This approach is reflected in the Dharavi Social Mission, which has become an important part of the redevelopment effort. Thousands of residents have already enrolled in livelihood and skill development programmes designed to improve employability and create new income opportunities. Women are being supported through entrepreneurship and self-employment initiatives, while children and youth are benefitting from programmes focused on education, health, nutrition, life skills and personal safety. Employment partnerships, healthcare camps and outreach initiatives are also helping connect families with government welfare schemes and essential services. Together, these efforts are ensuring that redevelopment begins with people and that social progress keeps pace with physical development.

People-led initiative

Perhaps the strongest endorsement of the project is coming from the people of Dharavi themselves. Families are voluntarily signing agreements and peacefully handing over their homes so that construction can begin. They are moving out with the hope of returning to their new homes at the earliest. Hundreds have already shifted to transit accommodation, and many speak of the cleaner surroundings, better civic facilities and improved living conditions they are experiencing there. They now look forward to the day they receive the keys to their own permanent homes. Their confidence reflects a growing belief that redevelopment is no longer a distant promise, but a reality taking shape before their eyes.



The same confidence is reflected in the survey process. Communities that had earlier expressed reservations, including parts of Kumbharwada and Compound 13, are now cooperating with household surveys and home numbering. More than 91,000 families overall have completed the household survey and are now waiting for their rehabilitation homes.